

Musings

1. Mandriva's drawbacks: ugly looks, occasional unresponsiveness, and the 5353 thing, plus trying to make KDE4 look like KDE3 on the outer surface.
2. GRUB2 included with Ubuntu and Kubuntu makes them un-chainloadable from the Windows boot manager, and can be booted from GRUB legacy -- but this needs a flabbergasting GRUB.CONF.
3. openSUSE 11.2 includes an old KDE4: 4.3.1, while the others include 4.3.2. No updates are available. Even with Amarok, its version 2.1.1, not 2.2—you'll need to pull the latest from the KDE Backports repo, manually.
4. Anti-aliased fonts need to be enabled manually via KDE system settings or Configure Desktop in GNOME, in openSUSE 11.2. Or else they look U-G-L-Y. And the fix is per-user only; KDM and YaST! running as root still display Monochrome fonts.
5. A stupid boot experience for non-KMS Ubuntu users—randomly, the entire boot happened in text mode.
6. Some encrypted home features in Ubuntu cannot be mounted in any other operating system—specifically, openSUSE and Mandriva. It did work in Sabayon Five Oh.

on my chassis was lit up like a Christmas tree. Killing the process made no difference at all, and then I ended up rebooting the PC, and everything was fine again. Mind though, this was RC2; I actually installed RC2 and then updated to finally using a DVD. It may have been fixed (though the Beagle package was not updated). Also, with openSUSE I could not manually mount the ECryptFS'd home from my Ubuntu; it gave me quite interesting filenames.

And Mandriva comes up with a bug now! Every 15 seconds or so, a notification comes up, saying "Linux.local is connecting on the 5353 service". It gets royally annoying. Tracking it down, I discovered that UDP port 5353 is used for multicast DNS (mDNS). I asked the Mandriva fan at LFY (who knows its internals more than he knows his own :-)) what mDNS was all about, and he pointed me towards Avahi. Disabling it fixed the problem.

Get to networking and Mandriva comes up with one slick feature. Mandriva includes support for something called Network Profiles—refer to Figure 16. Let's suppose you use a wired network at home, Wi-Fi with a corporate proxy at office, and a public profile with full firewall, DHCP and no network daemons in public places. With Network Profiles (accessible from MCC -> Network), you can create profiles of network settings, say one with static IP and no proxies for your home ADSL router; one with DHCP over Wi-Fi, and a corporate proxy for the office; one with

maximum security for public places like airports, and then switch between them at will. Pretty nifty, because at home it saves the overhead of a DHCP request. At the office it makes sure all the proxies and DHCP stuff work homogeneously all over the system, and in public places it maintains some sanitised security. Cool eh?

While we are at networking, openSUSE automatically detects if you are using a laptop or a desktop, and then uses the *ifconfig* on desktops (because they are mostly static) and NetworkManager on laptops. Ubuntu uses NetworkManager as the one-size-fits-all tool. While it works, there are dynamic configuration overheads.

The Good	Mandriva 2010
The Bad	openSUSE 11.2
The Ugly	(K)Ubuntu 9.10

Overall

openSUSE 11.2 left the best impression. Its absolutely killer looks, slick integration, superb tools and really good repository and package count makes it THE choice for all but novices or very finicky Linux users out there, Netbookers apart.

Ubuntu and brother Kubuntu are cool and minimalist. Perfect for people who want DEBs at all costs and want the system customised exactly their way. The light and minimalist nature of the system means it's a perfect choice for netbookers and low-end laptops. However, with only a frighteningly low 5 per cent of all Ubuntu users reporting that they had a flawless install (95 per cent said they had serious problems), it does put Ubuntu in a spot. Coupled with the emphasis on KMS and the resulting neglect of non-KMS users, this makes it to the second spot.

And staggeringly far behind, with its scary looks, its occasional unresponsiveness, a bloated software base and a very inconvenient installer, Mandriva makes it to the third spot. Only for switchovers from Windows (they'll love Mandy) and novice Linux users. Real men use openSUSE 11.2!

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